

Michelangelo Merisi da Caravaggio

“Archimedes”

1608-10



Author: Michelangelo Merisi da Caravaggio (1571-1610)

Collaborator: Mario Minniti, (1577- 1640) [Later interventions]

Subject: Archimedes

Date: 1608-10

Technique: Oil on canvas

Dimensions: 75 x 61 cm (Vertical rectangular format)

Format: rectangular vertical

Property: private

Discovered: 2023

Published: 2026

Provenance & Discovery

- Private Collection: Remaining in private hands for over 40 years.
- Public Debut: Formally presented on May 16, 2026, at the Monaco Symposium Caravaggio and Archimedes, launching its international scholarly debate.
- Scientific Consensus: Extensive technical, art-historical, and scientific analysis confirmed its significance.

Composition & Reworking

- The Layered Canvas: Research reveals a complex structural history—an underlying composition by Caravaggio, later altered by subsequent interventions.
- The Transformation: Significant reworking transformed an original military portrait into the figure of Archimedes, altering both its visual appearance and core meaning.
- Historical Context: Due to its chronology and ties to Caravaggio's Malta–Sicily period, scholars suggest the involvement of Mario Minniti in these later reworkings.

The Extent of the Repainting: From Warrior to Scholar

Anatomical & Attribute Alterations

- From Shield to Globe: The military shield was entirely replaced by a celestial or terrestrial globe.
- The Right Hand: Originally supporting the face, it was repainted to hold a compass.
- The Left Hand: Previously obscured while holding the shield, it is now visible and holds a palimpsest.
- Facial Features: The mustache and beard were lengthened to emphasize a scholarly, philosophical character.
- Anatomical Softening: The clavicular (collarbone) area was softened to diminish the original military build.
- Drapery: A covering scarf was added over the right shoulder.

Art-Historical Impact

- The Overpaint Misdirection: These extensive modifications misled experts for decades. Without laboratory testing, the naked eye could not pierce these later layers, leaving the painting dormant as an "unknown work."
- A Common Master Practice: Such structural alterations (pentimenti) were frequently practiced by Old Masters. Similar composite reworkings are well-documented and confirmed across several other verified paintings by Caravaggio.

- Iconographic Shift: These interventions fundamentally redefined the composition, shifting its narrative from a secular military portrait to a profound iconographic depiction of Archimedes.

Scientific Validation & Attribution

Comprehensive Technical Examination

- Multispectral Imaging: Infrared & Ultraviolet analysis, Hyperspectral camera tests, and X-ray examination.
- Elemental & Material Analysis: XRF (X-ray fluorescence), Paint & canvas analysis, and Energy-Dispersive Spectroscopy (EDS) via electron microscopy.
- Surface Analysis: Digital microscopy and rigorous technical comparisons.

Expert Endorsements

- Dr. Roberta Lapucci: Conducted the definitive technical report and art-historical reconstruction supporting the formal attribution to Caravaggio.
- Dr. Alessandra Gregori: Provided an independent art-historical assessment and formal evaluation of the work.
- Prof. Hassan Ugail (University of Bradford): Performed advanced computational authentication using a specialized deep learning algorithm to verify the stylistic attribution.

Additional Material Evidence & Conservation

Forensic & Physical Findings

- **The Medusa Discovery:** Traces of an earlier, underlying Medusa motif on a shield were identified. This is a monumental finding, as only two other Medusa depictions by Caravaggio are known to exist.
- **Workshop Signature:** Particles of quartz and glass were discovered within the paint layer, a materials-mixing technique uniquely characteristic of Caravaggio's workshop.
- **Biometric Evidence:** Two partial fingerprints were located and documented within the composition.
- **Hidden Inscriptions:** Cryptic marks and inscriptions, possibly representing numerical notations, were revealed beneath the later paint layers.

Conservation Status

- **Expert Restoration:** Professional conservation of the canvas was completed in 2023 by Dr. Roberta Lapucci.
- **Archival Record:** The entire conservation process was meticulously documented through high-resolution photography.

State of conservation

FRONT SIDE (BEFORE RESTORATION)



REVERSE SIDE (BEFORE RESTORATION)



FRONT SIDE (AFTER RESTORATION)



REVERSE SIDE (AFTER RESTORATION)



Historical and Artistic Significance

A Masterpiece of the Final Period

- A Monumental Discovery: Archimedes stands as one of the most significant rediscovered masterpieces from Caravaggio's dramatic final years.
- The Flight from Malta: Historical reconstruction suggests this was likely one of three canvases Caravaggio carried with him during his daring prison escape from Malta.
- The Sicilian Connection: The work ultimately reached Syracuse, where it underwent its profound iconographic transformation within the workshop of Mario Minniti.
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The Layered Narrative

- Dual Compositions: X-radiographic examination confirms a stunning coexistence—the hidden, underlying Medusa composition structurally bound beneath the visible figure of Archimedes.
- Global Academic Debut: Formally introduced to the world on May 16, 2026, at the Monaco Symposium Caravaggio and Archimedes, it has now become a cornerstone of international scholarly debate.

Compositional Genesis of the Painting

Analytical Methodology

The chronological sequence of the overlapping pictorial layers was established using cross-examination of surface edges via digital microscopy, visible light analysis, and X-radiography.

- The Foreground Shield: **Layer 1** (Deepest). The initial layer features the military shield, establishing the baseline composition.
- The Naked Torso: **Layer 2** The entire, exposed anatomical torso was painted over the structural baseline.
- The Head: **Layer 3** The anatomical features of the head were executed, establishing the figure's primary position.
- The Red Mantle: **Layer 4** The vibrant red mantle was introduced, draped over the right shoulder.
- The Final Attributes: **Layer 5** (Surface). The hands and the small book (palimpsest) were added in the final phase, completing the iconographic transformation.



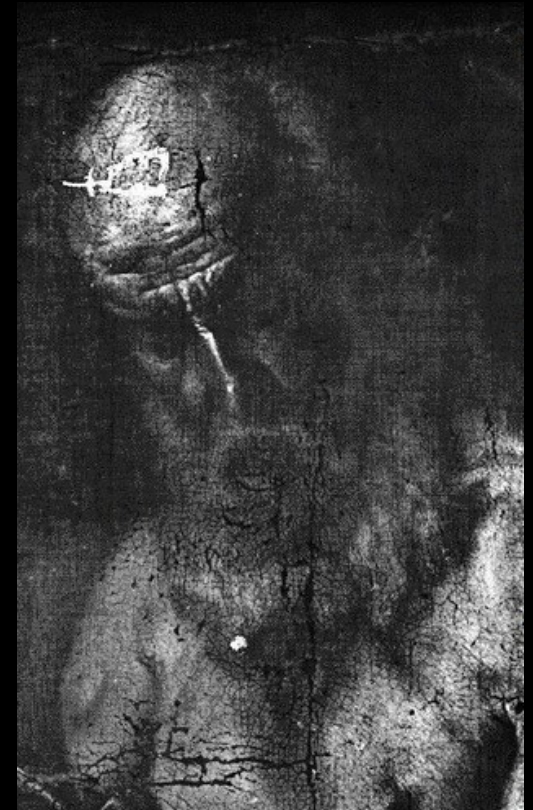
Anatomical Grafting & Model Identity

- The Grafted Face: The face does not align naturally with the torso, indicating it was painted over a pre-existing body at a later stage.



Caravaggio, 'Beheading of St John the Baptist', 1608, detail, Valletta, Malta

- The Maltese Technique: This matches Caravaggio's workflow in The Beheading of Saint John the Baptist, specifically the construction of the jailer.
- Philip de Wignacourt: The underlying portrait represents the brother of the Grand Master, who modeled for several of Caravaggio's late masterpieces (including the Maltese jailer and possibly the chief mourner in The Burial of Saint Lucy).



The Chest Inscription

- Post-Cleaning Revelation: Following recent conservation and cleaning, a faint under-layer inscription emerged on the figure's chest.
- Ambiguous Notations: The characters are partially obscured, tentatively read by researchers as «6» or «513».



Scholarly Interpretation:

- May represent mathematical or numerical notations linked to Archimedes' identity.
- Could be a hidden workshop code or historical inventory mark embedded beneath the surface.

X-Ray Structural Analysis

Conservation Artifacts

- Direct Retouching: The X-ray highlights areas where historical retouching was executed directly onto the paint layer without prior plaster filling (appearing as distinct dark/black zones).
- Forehead Damage: A distinct structural tear on the figure's forehead was historically stabilized and filled with plaster.
- Technical Value: These physical anomalies confirm the painting's age and document the raw, unpolished history of its past structural restorations.



Hyperspectral Camera Examination

- Initial Campaign: February 2022
- Revised Analysis: July 2023





UV Fluorescence Analysis

- Stratigraphy: Reveals three distinct levels of retouching and two layers of ancient, terpenic varnish (marked by green-yellow fluorescence).
- Restoration Marks: Plastering and pictorial retouchings appear as dark spots.

Chronology of Intervention:

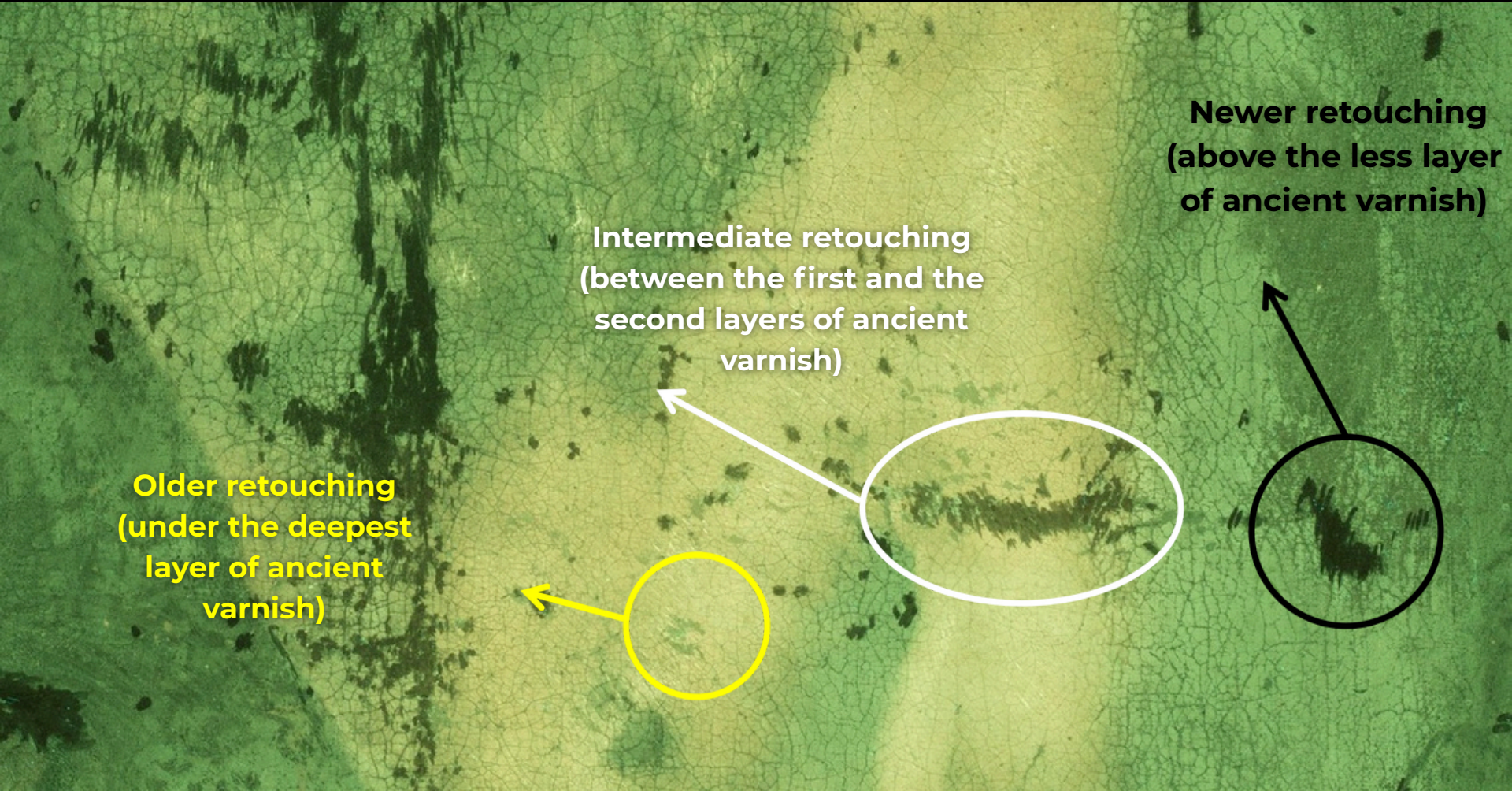
- Retouchings on top of the terpenic varnish appear darker.
- Retouchings underneath the varnish appear paler.

Three levels of retouching

Older retouching
(under the deepest
layer of ancient
varnish)

Intermediate retouching
(between the first and the
second layers of ancient
varnish)

Newer retouching
(above the less layer
of ancient varnish)



**Infrared
Reflectography**
(1300nm)



**Infrared
Reflectography**

(1500nm)



**Infrared
Reflectography**

(1900nm)



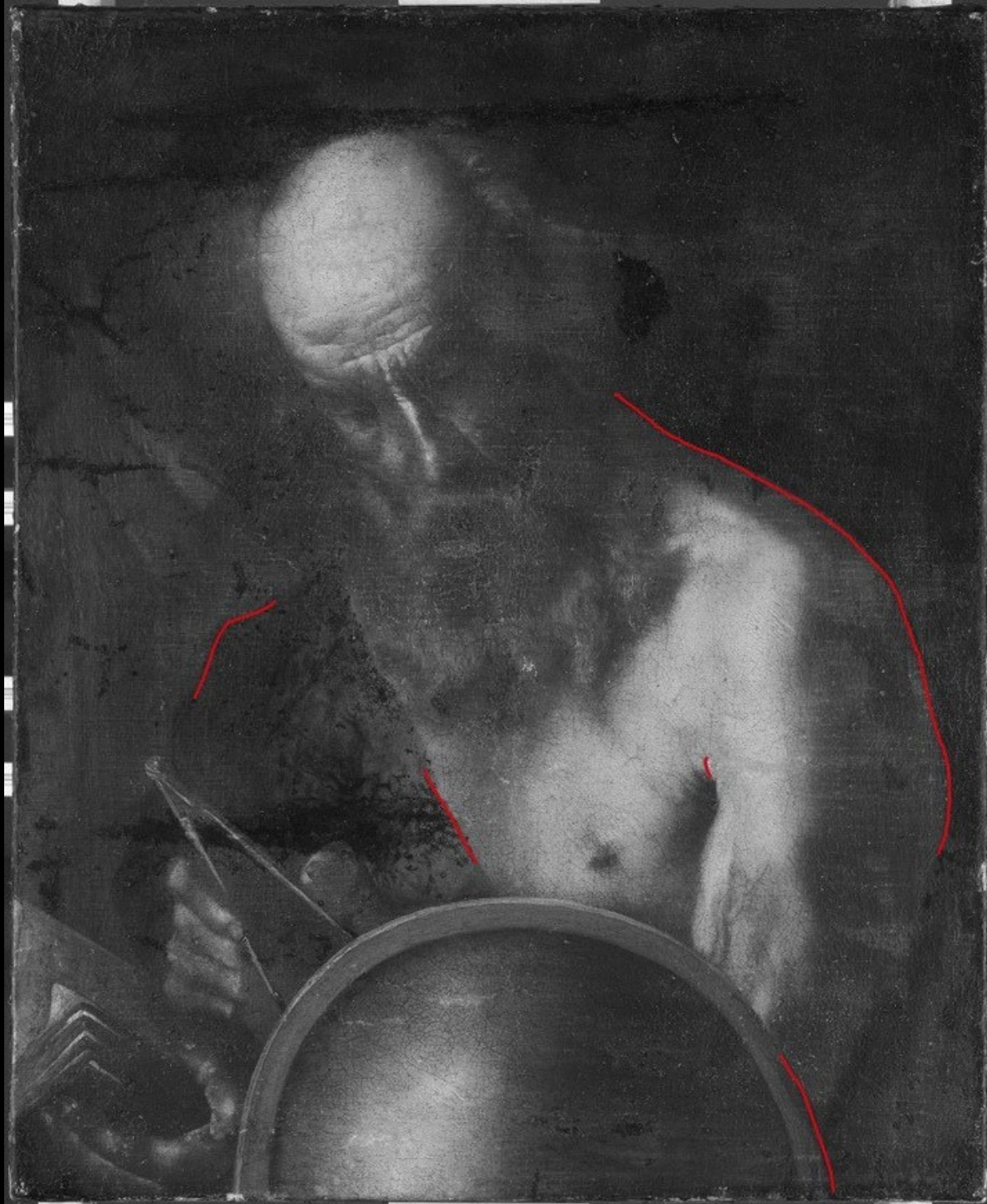
**Infrared
Reflectography**

(2200nm)



**Brush drawing
traces**

IRR



Hyper-spectral

Scanner



Hyper-spectral

Scanner



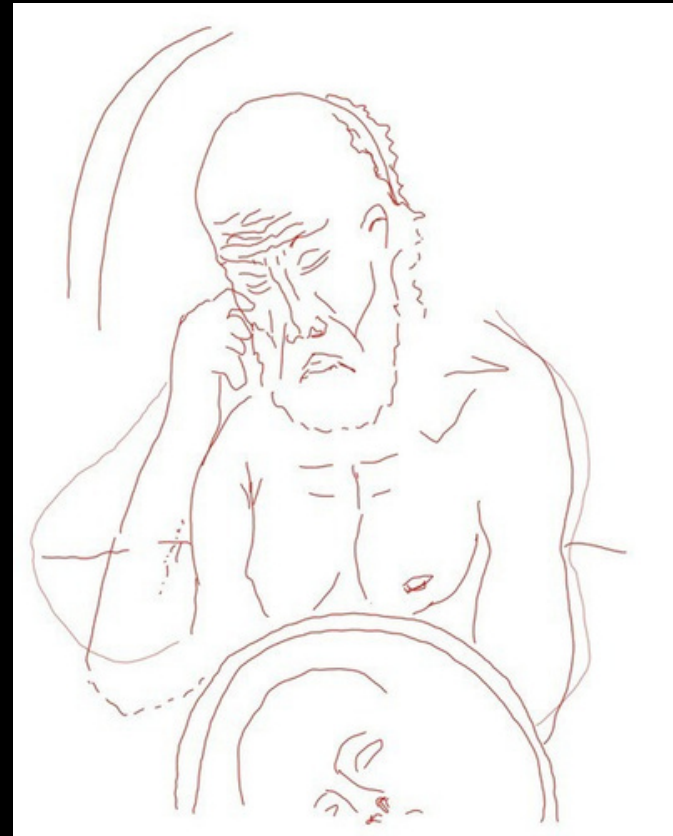
Hyper-spectral

Scanner



Comparison

VIS / graphic



X-Ray Revelations & Pentimenti

Technical Parameters

X-ray images were acquired using standard parameters optimized for Caravaggesque artworks, revealing an underlying, alternative composition:

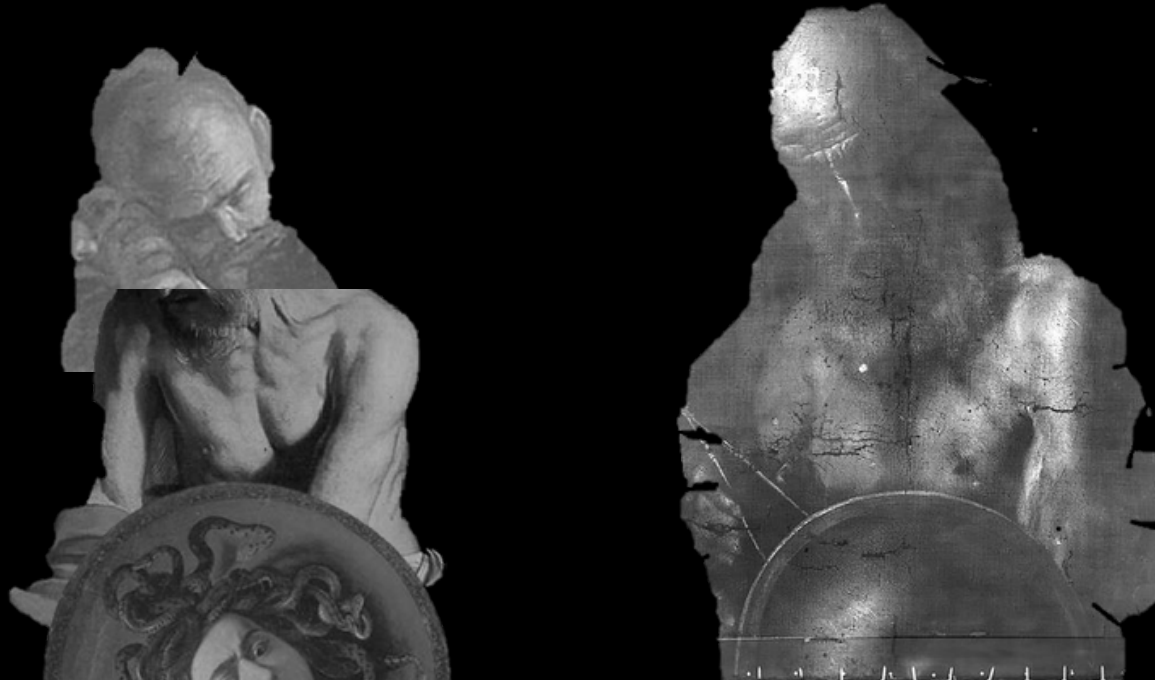
1. **Left Arm & Hand:** Originally bent, with the right cheek resting on it; shifted across two different positions.
2. **Architectural Element:** An arch opening visible in the background on the left.
3. **Anatomy & Mantle:** A naked torso detected beneath the red mantle, showing clear reprofiling along the left shoulder.
4. **The Shield:** The head of Medusa partially visible on the shield.
5. **The Beard:** Originally executed as a smaller beard.
6. **Head Contour:** A clear pentimento on the top edge, indicating the head was originally smaller.



Composite Composition Analysis

Multiprojected Caravaggio Sketches:

- Head: Sourced from The Burial of Saint Lucy.
- Torso: Sourced from Saint Jerome.
- Shield: Sourced from Medusa.



New Chemical Analysis (June 2023)

Stratigraphic Testing

(EDS) – Sent to Dr. Mirella Baldan Three new acquisition points were sampled to verify underlying composition hypotheses:

1. The Shield: Targeted where the forehead of Medusa is visible in X-rays.
2. The Red Mantle: Aimed at detecting the flesh tones of the underlying torso.
3. The Cheek: Located adjacent to the cheek, where the underlying hand and arm appear in X-rays.



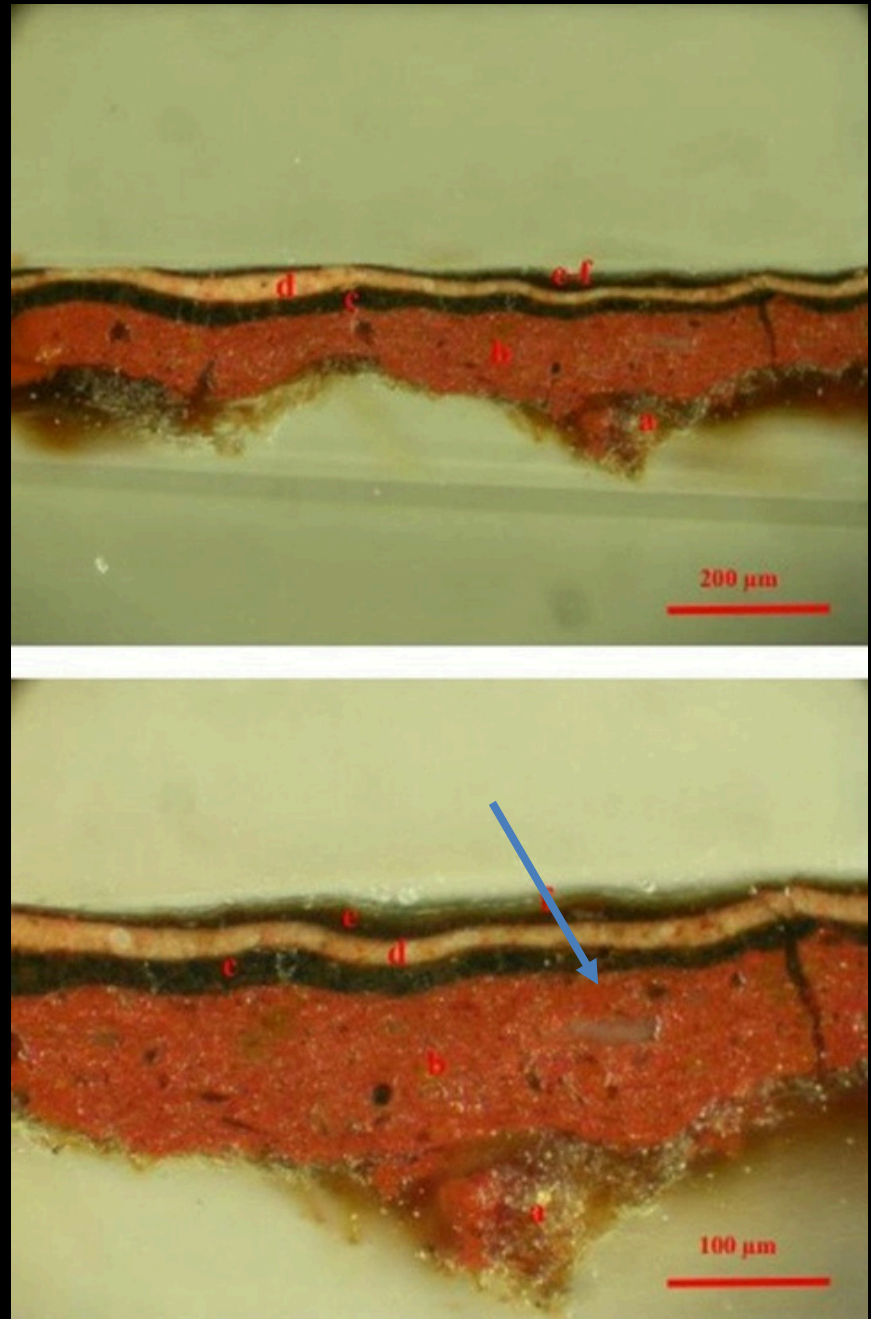
Additional Material Analysis

- Request: Evaluation to confirm a new material detected by naked eye.
- Observation: Crystalline quartz/glass granules efflorescing on the painting's surface.



Previous Chemical Tests

- Initial Discovery: Early samples analyzed by Dr. Baldan already indicated the presence of glass or quartz fragments within the paint layers.



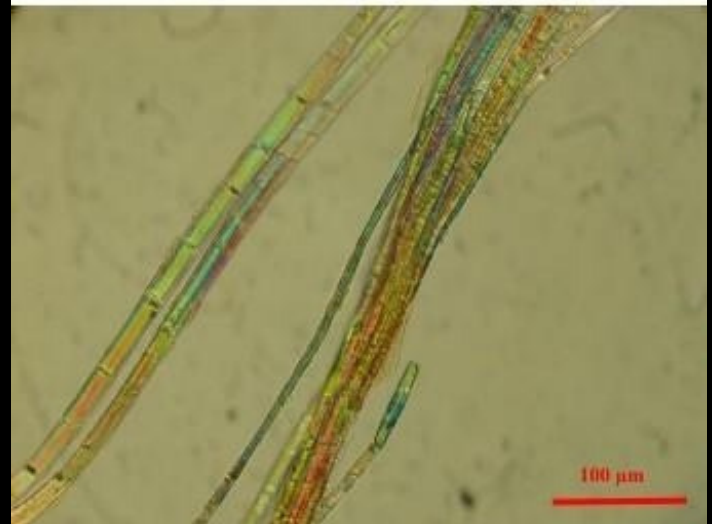
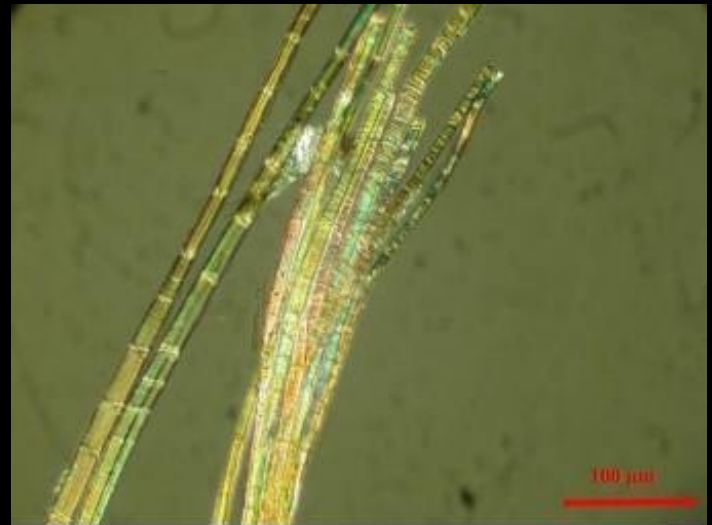
Sample

Flesh



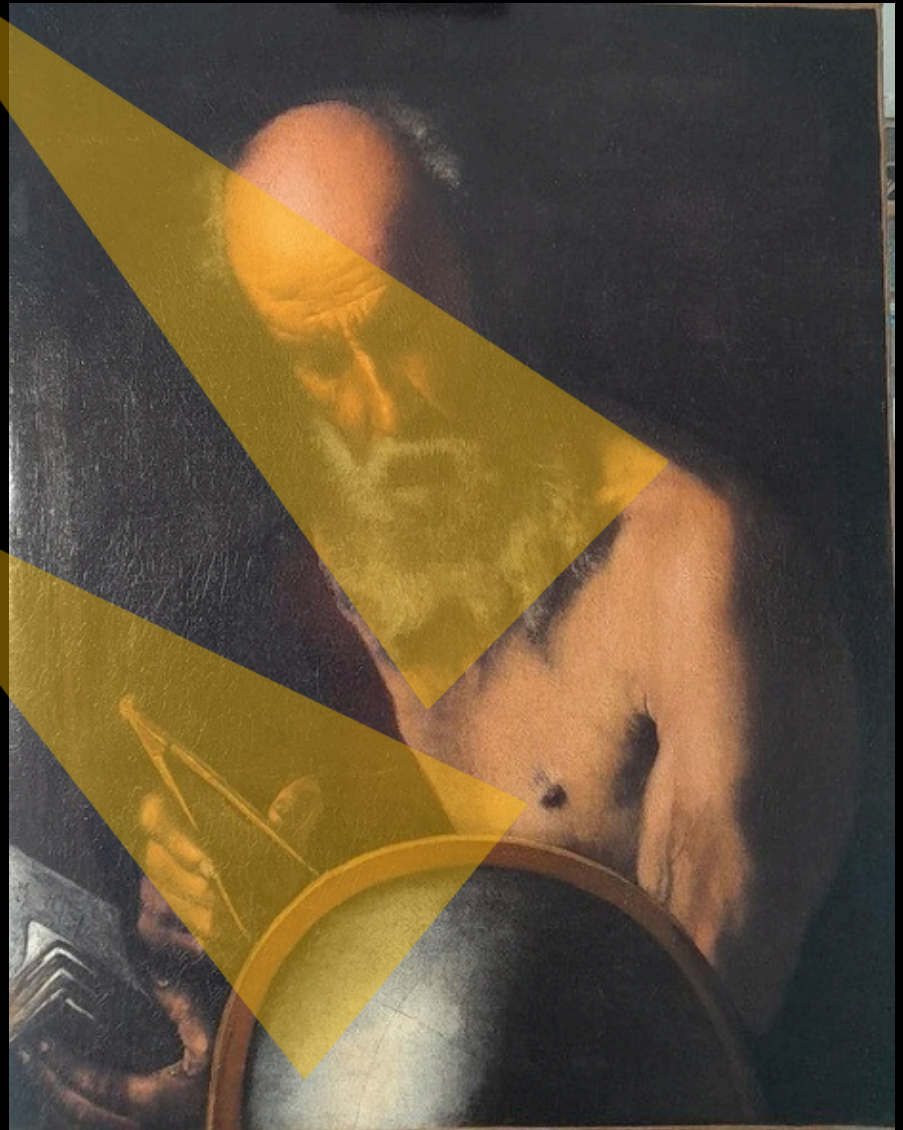
Sample

Canvas



Graphic Chart of Light Sources

- Configuration: Two distinct light sources coming from the left, positioned slightly forward from the artwork's vertical plane.
- Target Areas:
 - Source 1: Illuminates the head and the torso.
 - Source 2: Illuminates the shield (originating from a lower focal point).
- Beam Angle: Features a restricted cone of light, approximately 18° to 20° .
- Art Historical Context: This dual light source configuration is highly characteristic of Caravaggio's smaller works executed during his Sicilian and Maltese periods.



Conclusions

- **Authenticity & Dating:** Technical data confirms compatibility with Michelangelo Merisi (Caravaggio), dating the work to the early 17th century.
- **Altered Dimensions:** The canvas was originally larger and has been cut down on three sides (excluding the top edge).
- **Layer Discrepancy:** A sharp contrast exists between the high-quality underlying sketch and the final surface layer, which is of uneven quality (head is superior, hands are inferior).
- **Compositional Evolution:** The underlying sketch represents a genuine Caravaggio composition—originally an initial portrait of Alof de Wignacourt—later modified to depict Archimedes.
- **Division of Hands:**
 - Caravaggio: Executed the priming, underlying paint layers, face, torso, and the shield.
 - Mario Minniti: Intervened later to complete the second version, adding the compass, hands, left side of the mantle, and portions of the books.

Report on Computer Assisted Analysis

of a painting attributed to **Caravaggio** by
Professor Hassan Ugail. Professor of visual
computing and Artificial Intelligence
an internationally renowned specialist in the area of
computer-based image analysis 04 August 2024

Statement of Compliance

I confirm that I have made clear which facts and matters referred to in this report are within my own knowledge and which are not. Those that are within my own knowledge, I confirm to be true. The opinions I have expressed represent my true and complete professional judgement on the matters to which they refer.

Professor Hassan Ugail
4 August 2024

The AI-assisted comparative analysis supported the hypothesis that significant parts of the painting correspond to known authenticated works by Caravaggio, strengthening the broader technical and art-historical attribution.



Figure 1: Image provided for the analysis.

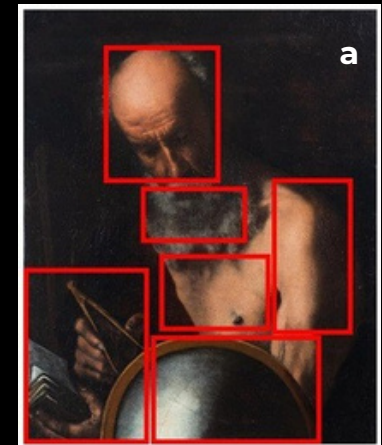
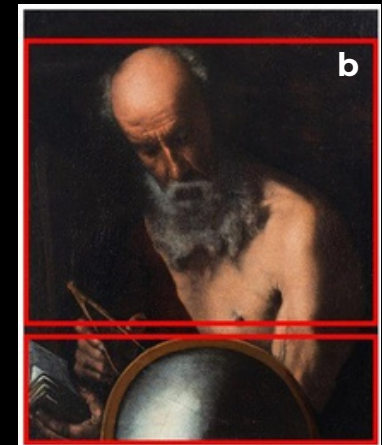


Figure 2: Parts of the image considered for the analysis.



Instructions

An image of a painting (shown in Figure 1) was provided for analysis to assess the likelihood that parts of the painting is the work of the Italian painter Michelangelo Merisi da Caravaggio (Caravaggio).

Results of the Analysis

The results of the analysis are shown in Figure 3 where the given parts of the images are compared with well-known images of authentic paintings by Caravaggio (as detailed in the Appendix).

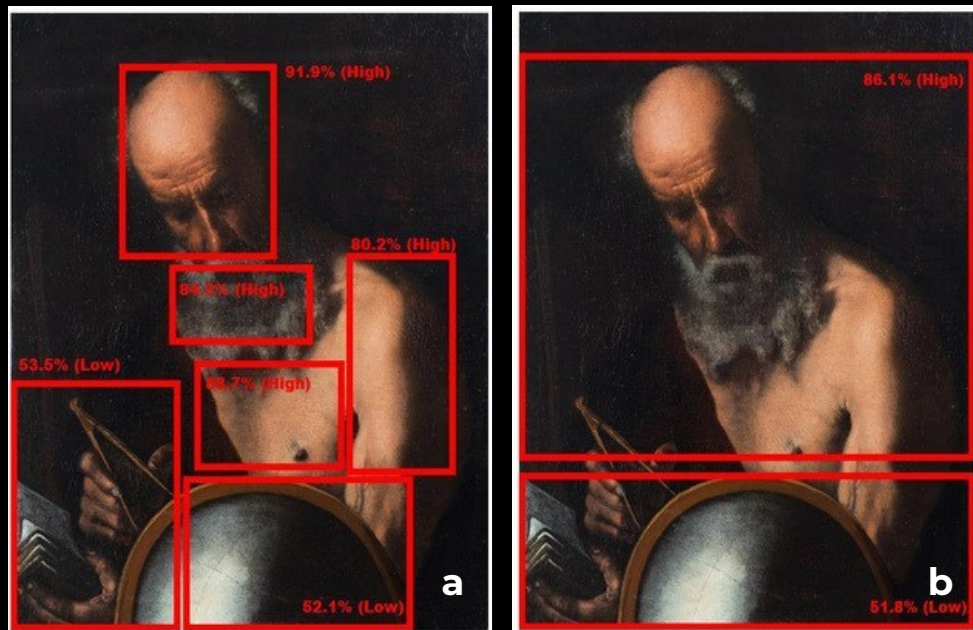


Figure 3a: Results of the analysis showing the degree of similarity between the selected parts of the image and that of authentic paintings by Caravaggio.

Note: a similarity index of 75% or higher for a given test image part compared with a dataset of authentic images indicates clear evidence of authorship. The results indicate that the upper part (top part shown in Figure 3b) of the painting has a high degree of similarity indicating strong likelihood that it is the work of Caravaggio while lower part (lower part shown in figure 3b) has a low degree of similarity indicating it is unlikely to be the work of Caravaggio.

Procedural Approach

The process of analysing paintings using an artificial intelligence-assisted deep learning approach begins with gathering a collection of known authentic artworks by the painter.

This collection is carefully prepared to ensure that the images are consistent in size and quality, allowing the computer to focus on the important artistic details rather than being distracted by differences in the composition.

A machine learning algorithm based on artificial neural networks is deployed to analyse the images and compare them against the questionable painting. This approach excels at recognising intricate patterns in images to learn the uniqueness among the authentic paintings in the dataset.

It can meticulously examine each painting in the dataset, identifying and learning a wide array of features such as the colour palette used, tonal values, hues, the light and shadow effects, and the unique ways the artist applies brushstrokes. Such features, along with many other thousands of "deep features", are extracted from the artworks.

This learning phase allows the computer to understand and catalogue thousands of such details from each painting, effectively capturing the essence of the artist's unique style.

With this information, the system then creates a "digital fingerprint" for the artist, forming a unique signature based on the patterns and features it has learned.

When a new "test" painting is introduced, the system uses its learned knowledge to analyse and extract the same kind of detailed features from this questionable painting and make a comparison to quantify the degree of similarity. The heart of the process involves comparing these details with the "digital fingerprint" of the artist to examine how closely they match.

It is important to highlight that this comparison is not just about finding exact matches but understanding the degree of similarity between the painting in question and the established digital signature based on the authentic paintings of the artist. Through this comparison, the system can make educated guesses about the likelihood that the unknown work is by the artist, or even if it is a forgery.

Whilst it is not a confirmation, as a measure of comparison, a similarity index of 75% or higher for a given test image compared with a dataset of authentic images indicate a high likelihood that the artist painted it. The methodology used for this work is described in detail in Ugail et al., (2024), (2023) and (2022).

Biography of the Analyst

Professor Hassan Ugail stands as a world expert in visual computing and has made significant contributions to the field of AI- assisted art analysis, especially in the authentication of historical artworks through advanced machine learning techniques.

With over thirty years of experience in computer science, he currently leads the Centre for Visual Computing and Intelligent Systems at the University of Bradford, United Kingdom. His work spans advanced image recognition, facial analysis, medical imaging, and artificial intelligence systems applied to visual interpretation.

His expertise has been crucial in the development of advanced computational methods for image analysis and pattern recognition, allowing a more precise understanding of artistic structures, brushwork, and compositional consistency.

In the field of art authentication, Professor Ugail has developed innovative AI-based methodologies capable of identifying stylistic and structural consistencies within disputed paintings. His research focuses on deep-feature analysis, comparative pattern recognition, and computational visual diagnostics.

His work has demonstrated how artificial intelligence can support traditional connoisseurship, technical diagnostics, and scientific investigation, opening new perspectives in attribution studies and the examination of workshop collaborations.

The methodology applied in the analysis of the present analysis reflects this interdisciplinary approach, combining technological precision with art-historical evaluation.

Selected Media Coverage

The following references highlight Professor Ugail’s public recognition and the comparative dataset used in the present AI-supported attribution analysis.

Selected Press Coverage

Lost Raphael masterpiece goes on show in
Bradford in UK
— BBC
Mystery of Raphael masterpiece may have
been solved by Bradford-made AI
— The Guardian
This Raphael masterpiece isn’t quite what it
seems
— CNN

AI says a painting was made by the master
Raphael
— The Washington Post
AI uncovers hidden secret in painting by
Raphael
— Forbes
Attributed to Raphael thanks to Artificial
Intelligence goes on public view
— Artnet News

Appendix

List of paintings used for machine learning comparison.

c. 1592–1593: Boy Peeling Fruit	1602: John the Baptist
c. 1592–1599: Portrait of a Prelate	1602: Taking of Christ
c. 1593: Young Sick Bacchus	1603: Sacrifice of Isaac
c. 1593: Boy with a Basket of Fruit	c. 1603: Entombment
c. 1594: Fortune Teller	1603: Crowning with Thorns
c. 1595: Saint Francis of Assisi in Ecstasy	c. 1604: Madonna of Loreto
c. 1596: Lute Player	1604: John the Baptist
c. 1597: Medusa	c. 1604: The Calling of Saints Peter and Andrew
c. 1597: Portrait of a Courtesan	c. 1605: Saint Jerome in Meditation
c. 1598: Saint Catherine of Alexandria	1606: Madonna and Child with Saint Anne (Dei Palafrenieri)
c. 1598: Sacrifice of Isaac	1601–1606: Death of the Virgin
c. 1598: Martha and Mary Magdalene	1606: Mary Magdalen in Ecstasy
c. 1598: Portrait of Maffeo Barberini	c. 1606: Saint Francis in Meditation
c. 1598: Judith Beheading Holofernes	1606: Supper at Emmaus
c. 1599: David and Goliath	1607: Seven Works of Mercy
c. 1600: Boy Bitten by a Lizard	1607: Crucifixion of Saint Andrew
c. 1600: Calling of Saint Matthew	1607: David with the Head of Goliath
1601: Crucifixion of Saint Peter	1607: Madonna of the Rosary (Madonna del Rosario)
1602: Supper at Emmaus	1607: Crowning with Thorns
1602: Amor Victorious	c. 1607: Flagellation of Christ
1602: Inspiration of Saint Matthew	

c. 1607: Salome with the Head of John the Baptist
1607: Saint Jerome Writing
1607: Ecce Homo
1608: Annunciation
1608: The Burial of Saint Lucy
1609: Raising of Lazarus
1609: Adoration of the Shepherds
1609: Salome with the Head of John the Baptist
1610: Denial of Saint Peter
c. 1610: Saint Francis in Prayer
c. 1610: John the Baptist
c. 1610: John the Baptist
1610: David with the Head of Goliath
1610: John the Baptist
1610: Martyrdom of Saint Ursula

Experts Involved in the Authentication Process

Dr. Roberta Lapucci is an Italian art historian, conservator, and researcher whose work has long focused on the technical, material, and diagnostic study of old master painting, with particular expertise in the art of Michelangelo Merisi da Caravaggio. Over several decades, she has developed a distinctive interdisciplinary approach that brings together art-historical research, conservation practice, scientific analysis, and close visual examination. Her work is especially recognized for its attention to the technical construction of paintings, the role of optics and image transfer, the reading of stratigraphy and pentimenti, and the interpretation of hidden or altered pictorial layers revealed through diagnostic methods.



Throughout her career, Dr. Lapucci has combined scholarship with practical restoration experience. She has taught conservation, artistic techniques, and diagnostics in advanced and postgraduate contexts linked to Florence, and her academic and professional activity has been shaped by a constant dialogue between the studio, the laboratory, and the historical archive. This combination of practical and intellectual expertise has enabled her to make original contributions to the understanding of artistic process, workshop practice, and the complex material lives of paintings. Dr. Lapucci is also widely known for her studies on Caravaggio and for her sustained engagement with the technical problems surrounding his painting method.

Her research has explored questions of execution, sequencing, light, optics, and the relation between invention and process in works by Caravaggio and artists in his circle. She is the author of *Caravaggio and Optics*, a publication associated with her long-standing interest in the painter's technical procedures and in the broader question of how scientific observation can deepen art-historical understanding.

In addition to her research and teaching, Dr. Lapucci has organized and contributed to exhibitions and publications, always maintaining a strong interest in the relationship between connoisseurship and scientific evidence. Her work is characterized by methodological care: rather than relying on simplified claims, she emphasizes the need to examine each object through a combination of documentary evidence, historical comparison, stylistic reading, and diagnostic investigation.

Her current work includes the study of the Caravaggio / Minniti case and the forthcoming publication devoted to the painting identified as *Archimedes* (1608-10), a work from a private collection examined through extensive diagnostic and historical research. In her current lecture and publication project, Dr. Lapucci explores the possibility that the underlying image may preserve an abandoned Caravaggio abbozzo later reworked by Mario Minniti, opening a broader discussion on artistic collaboration, unfinished sketches, and the transformation of one pictorial idea into another.

It is this combination of depth, precision, and interdisciplinary method that makes Dr. Lapucci's contribution especially significant for the Monaco symposium.

Dr. Alessandra Gregori is a prominent Italian specialist in the authentication, attribution, and valuation of Old Master paintings, with particular expertise in works by Caravaggio and the complex artistic production associated with his international circle.

She is the niece of the legendary Professor Mina Gregori one of the most respected and foundational authorities in modern Caravaggio studies. Carrying forward this distinguished scholarly lineage, Dr. Gregori continues a rigorous tradition of traditional connoisseurship, archival analysis, and deep historical research into Italian Baroque painting. Her work routinely bridges the gap between stylistic analysis, historical context, and the fine-grained questions of disputed authorship.



Her professional activity focuses on connoisseurship, forensic provenance research, and the evaluation of complex, high-stakes attribution cases. By combining exact art-historical analysis with acute practical market expertise, she provides comprehensive evaluations that satisfy both academic standards and the commercial art world.

In the Archimedes case, Dr. Gregori provided a critical, independent art-historical assessment and structural valuation of the canvas. Furthermore, she served as the scientific moderator for the Monaco Symposium, playing a pivotal role in publically presenting the painting and orchestrating its examination within an international framework of leading consensus scholars.

Dr. Barbara Savina is an Italian art historian and specialist in Caravaggio studies, with academic expertise in iconography, technical diagnostics, and the study of Caravaggesque copies and workshop practices. She studied at the University of Rome La Sapienza, where she graduated in Iconography and Iconology. She later specialized with a thesis entitled Diagnostic Investigations on Caravaggio's Paintings and completed a PhD in Tools and Methods for Art History, focusing on copies and variants connected to Caravaggio's oeuvre.

For several years, Dr. Savina collaborated in academic teaching and research, later teaching art history at the G. d'Annunzio University of Chieti as well as humanities in Roman secondary schools. She has authored numerous publications on Roman art of the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries, with particular emphasis on Caravaggesque painting, attribution studies, and workshop practices.

She has also collaborated with the Soprintendenza ai Beni Artistici e Storici di Roma on exhibitions and cultural projects.



Since 2009, she has worked as an educational specialist at the Vatican Museums, combining scholarship, public education, and curatorial experience. At the Monaco Symposium, Dr. Savina contributes an important scholarly perspective on workshop practice, copies, and the transmission of Caravaggio's visual language, offering essential context for understanding the relationship between original invention and later reinterpretation in the Archimedes case.

Dr. Barbara Savina: Expert Assessment

Regarding Archimedes, Dr. Barbara Savina considers the painting an important example of the collaboration between Caravaggio and Mario Minniti during the Master's Sicilian period. According to her analysis, the composition presents a distinctly Caravaggesque structure. This is evident in the figure's concentrated pose, the dramatic use of chiaroscuro, and a perspectival construction based on intersecting diagonals that powerfully guide the viewer's gaze.

Dr. Savina highlights significant stylistic and technical affinities with other works by Merisi. She finds highly convincing the hypothesis proposed by Dr. Roberta Lapucci: that Caravaggio conceived and initiated the composition in an early phase—possibly reusing preparatory sketches—while the execution was later completed by Minniti in Syracuse. Furthermore, she connects the artwork to Caravaggio's broader experimental interest in optics, image transposition techniques, and the scientific legacy of Archimedes himself.

“Further technical investigations may shed new light on the authorship of the painting and its possible identification with the Archimedes recorded in the nineteenth-century Azzi-Vitelleschi inventories.”

Dr. Barbara Savina

Monaco Symposium, Monaco 16 May 2026

Dr. Fabio Scaletti is an Italian scholar, writer, and cultural commentator whose work moves across philosophy, intellectual history, literature, and the study of art. His profile is marked by an interdisciplinary approach that does not isolate works of art from the wider worlds of ideas, language, symbolism, and historical thought, but instead seeks to understand them within broader cultural and philosophical frameworks. This breadth of interest makes his contribution especially valuable in contexts where painting is not considered merely as an object of style or attribution, but as a point of encounter between artistic invention, historical consciousness, and the enduring structures of European culture.

Born in Milan in 1964, Dr. Scaletti graduated in Philosophy in 1988 and later completed a Master's degree in Business Communication. Over the course of his career, he has developed a distinctive voice as both an essayist and a public intellectual, writing on themes that range from philosophical inquiry to the interpretation of visual culture and the legacy of the Italian artistic tradition. His work reflects a sustained commitment to the life of ideas and to the role of interpretation in reconnecting artworks with the intellectual climates from which they emerged.

An expert on Caravaggio, he has published in journals and books, focusing in particular on the Renaissance and on the attribution of works of art. His specialization in Caravaggio has been followed by a systematic study of major figures in the history of Italian Renaissance art, from Leonardo to Michelangelo and Raphael, on whom he has published acclaimed monographs.



His latest book is dedicated to Giotto (2025), and he is currently preparing a volume on Titian. His current work includes the newly released edition of his book Caravaggio. Catalogue Raisonne, which he will present in part at the Monaco Symposium in the context of a broader discussion on the latest attributions to Caravaggio, including new paintings, replicas, collaborative works, and lost paintings, together with a reflection on the methods and criteria used in attributing a painting to the great Lombard master.

Dr. Fabio Scaletti: Archimedes

Regarding the painting known as Archimedes, Dr. Fabio Scaletti observed that its underlying structure appears closely related to works securely associated with Caravaggio's late period. Following his examination of the technical documentation presented at the Monaco Symposium, Scaletti noted in particular the strong structural resemblance between the torso and Caravaggio's Saint Jerome in Valletta.

According to his assessment, the underlying composition was likely executed by Caravaggio, while the visible upper layer represents a later reinterpretation and completion by Mario Minniti.

His contribution to the Monaco Symposium brings an important art-historical and methodological perspective to the ongoing discussion surrounding the Archimedes case. Through his work on Caravaggio studies and attribution history, Dr. Scaletti helps situate the painting within a broader scholarly framework of authorship, collaboration, and unfinished invention in the late phase of Caravaggio's career.

"The hypothesis that the painting preserves an underlying Caravaggio conception, later reinterpreted and completed by Mario Minniti, seems reasonable to me."

Dr. Fabio Scaletti

Monaco Symposium, Monaco 16 May 2026

Mr. Jovan Mizzi is a Maltese independent researcher specializing in Caravaggio studies, attribution research, and provenance investigations. Originally trained as a marine engineer, he developed an analytical approach grounded in logical consistency, direct observation, and the careful examination of unresolved anomalies. His later experience in photography and the family antiques business deepened his understanding of visual perception, craftsmanship, and authenticity.

Since 2001, Mizzi has worked closely with scholars, collectors, restorers, and scientists in the study of paintings associated with Caravaggio and his circle, with particular focus on historical inventories, provenance reconstruction, and unresolved attribution questions.

At the Monaco Symposium, as Guest of Honour, Mizzi contributed an important historical and Mediterranean perspective, helping to situate the Archimedes case within the broader context of Caravaggio's Sicilian and Maltese years, his collaborations, and the complex transmission of his artistic legacy.



Mr. Jovan Mizzi: A Personal Reflection on Archimedes

After the remarkable presentations by Dr. Roberta Lapucci, Dr. Barbara Savina and Dr Fabio Scaletti, who explored the painting from technical, historical and conservation perspectives, I would like to offer a personal observation.

In 2018 I had the privilege of examining a painting together with restorers from the Hermitage Museum. During our discussion they pointed out a minute pictorial detail which, in their opinion, was characteristic of Caravaggio's hand. Eight years later, while standing before Archimedes, I was struck when a dedicated student of Caravaggio, independently drew my attention to a remarkably similar feature beneath the figure's shoulder. Such observations do not constitute proof, but they are the sort of small, recurring signals that remain in one's memory.

Another memory dates from 2003, when Dr. Mina Gregori kindly allowed me to visit a still-life exhibition in Florence before its official opening, as I was due to leave the city before the inauguration. Among the many works awaiting installation was a recently rediscovered *Lute Player*. At the time I was not particularly moved by it, though I naturally kept my thoughts to myself. Three years later I encountered the same painting in Düsseldorf. Properly displayed, illuminated and given space, it seemed transformed. It had come alive.

That experience led me to a simple conclusion. Great paintings behave like energy absorbers: they return what is given to them. Light, space, distance and the movement of the viewer all become part of the experience.

I have tested this impression repeatedly. For me it occurs with Caravaggio and with certain other great masters, but rarely with his followers. The difference can be subtle, yet it is tangible-rather like the difference between a living person and a perfect wax figure. This, perhaps, is my own definition of connoisseurship.

After a long day of presentations in Monaco, Archimedes was finally unveiled. My immediate impression was that the painting possessed precisely that quality of presence. It commanded attention.

Later I sat below the painting, slightly to the right. From that position the image seemed to acquire another dimension of meaning, much as many of Caravaggio's works reveal new aspects of their narrative when viewed from an oblique angle. I am reminded of the *Denial of Saint Peter* in New York and the *Cardsharps* at the Kimbell Art Museum in Fort Worth, to name but two examples where Caravaggio's storytelling appears to unfold differently as the viewer changes position.

Wanting to test whether this impression was merely subjective, I invited Dr Katarzyna Papiez a medical surgeon with no particular involvement in art history to view the painting from the same position. To my surprise, she immediately perceived something similar. Unfortunately, the painting was soon whisked away, and with it the opportunity to explore this observation further and see whether it resonated with other viewers. Whether these impressions can ever be measured is another matter. What I can say is that the painting possesses undeniable power and considerable potential. Some works invite analysis; others invite experience. *Archimedes*, in my view, does both.

Professor Hassan Ugail from the University of Bradford is a leading researcher in artificial intelligence, visual computing, and computational image analysis, with significant contributions to the technical study and authentication of historical paintings. His work gained international recognition through the Raphael attribution case of Madonna della Rosa, where computational examination revealed significant inconsistencies within the painting, contributing to a broader scholarly discussion concerning authorship and workshop intervention. Professor Ugail's methods combine computer vision, facial recognition, and comparative visual diagnostics, offering a new technical framework for the study of attribution and authenticity in Old Master paintings. In the Archimedes case, his AI-based comparative analysis played a crucial role in evaluating the relationship between the examined work and authenticated paintings by Caravaggio, providing additional technical evidence within the wider interdisciplinary investigation.



His research contributes to the growing integration of computational analysis into art-historical and technical diagnostics, offering new comparative tools for the examination of complex attribution cases. Professor Ugail's analysis indicated that selected upper sections of Archimedes show significant visual and structural similarity with authenticated works by Caravaggio, contributing an important layer of technical evidence to the attribution of the painting.

Thank you for your attention.

